CASE STUDY SERIES

SCALING UP INNOVATIVE FINANCE FOR GENDER EQUALITY AND WOMEN'S EMPOWERMENT

LESSONS FROM UN WOMEN'S GLOBAL PRACTICES

UN WOMEN

FOR ALL WOMEN AND GIRLS

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LUXEMBOURG
AID & DEVELOPMENT

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Economic Empowerment Section
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ACRONYMS

AfDB	African Development Bank
AICS	Italian Agency for Development Cooperation
AIIB	Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank
ARD Saint-Louis	Agence Régionale de Développement de Saint-Louis
BANOBRAS	National Works and Public Services Bank (Mexico)
CABEI	Central American Bank for Economic Integration
CBL	Central Bank of Liberia
CMU	National Health Insurance Agency (Senegal)
CSO	Civil Society Organization
ENIF	National Financial Inclusion Strategy (Guatemala)
ESG	Environmental, Social and Governance
EU	European Union
FAO	Food and Agriculture Organization
FfD	Financing for Development
FIDEIMAS	Trust Fund of the National Institute for Social Welfare (Costa Rica)
FiCS	Finance in Common
FIRA	Trust Funds for Rural Development (Mexico)
FSD Africa	Financial Sector Deepening Africa
GFC	Green Finance Committee (China)
GEWE	Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment
GIZ	German Corporation for International Cooperation
ICMA	International Capital Market Association
ICT	Information and Communication Technology
IDB	Inter-American Development Bank
IFC	International Finance Corporation
ILO	International Labour Organization
IMAS	National Institute for Social Welfare (Costa Rica)
MDBs	Multilateral Development Banks
MDPI	Multidimensional Poverty Index
MSME	Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises
NDMA	National Disaster Management Agency (Liberia)
ODA	Official Development Assistance
OECD	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
PDBs	Public Development Banks
PSX	Pakistan Stock Exchange
REIF	Renewable Energy Innovation Fund (Uruguay)
REFAN	Network of Women Farmers of the North (Senegal)
SDG	Sustainable Development Goals
SECP	Securities and Exchange Commission of Pakistan
SHCP	Ministry of Finance and Public Credit (Mexico)
SME	Small and Medium Enterprises
TEB Bank	Türk Ekonomi Bankası (Turkey)
UBS	Union Bank of Switzerland
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
UNEP	United Nations Environment Programme
UNIDO	United Nations Industrial Development Organization
UN Women	United Nations Entity for Gender Equality and the Empowerment of Women
USAID	United States Agency for International Development
VSLA	Village Savings and Loans Association
WEPs	Women's Empowerment Principles
WRI	World Resources Institute

INTRODUCTION

The concept of “sustainable finance” or “innovative finance” are referred in an interchangeable way in the international development field and financial system. While there is no single agreed definition of innovative financing, it is generally accepted to include financing mechanisms and solutions that mobilize, govern, or distribute funds beyond Official Development Assistance (ODA).*

With traditional development finance—particularly Official Development Assistance (ODA)—falling far short of the global needs to finance sustainable development, including gender equality objectives, alternative funding sources and financing mechanisms are essential to achieving success. In line with the UN’s focus on Financing for Development (FfD) and its call to align private financial resources with economic, social, and environmental goals—as reinforced by the Addis Ababa Action Agenda—UN Women has launched critical initiatives to ensure that FfD is gender-responsive. These efforts recognize that mobilizing private capital is vital to advancing both gender equality and global sustainability.

Key barriers—such as limited awareness, technical expertise, innovation, and the absence of standards for gender-lens investing—continue to constrain private financing flows toward gender outcomes. Moreover, transparency and accountability gaps around measurable gender impacts undermine the effectiveness of gender-focused financing. In response, UN Women launched its sustainable finance portfolio in 2020, aiming to shape a transformative, gender-responsive financial landscape and catalyse financing for gender equality through innovative solutions.

1. United Nations Economist Network. 2023. Policy Brief Innovative Financing Mechanism and Solutions.

This portfolio is structured around three core pillars:

1. **Convening and partnerships:** UN Women engages public and private sector leaders, as well as civil society, to influence the direction of capital and foster dialogue on sustainable finance for SDG 5. These efforts strengthen commitments and facilitate knowledge sharing on financing for gender equality.
2. **Market infrastructure and standard setting:** By developing principles, standards and guidelines for gender-lens investing, UN Women promotes a credible and impactful gender-lens investment market, encouraging growth in this emerging field.
3. **Technical assistance and capacity-building:** Supporting the development of innovative financing instruments, UN Women offers technical assistance across sovereign, public and private finance to build capacity and advance impactful gender-focused financial solutions.

Over four years, substantial progress has been made in supporting governments and financial systems to align investments with national development goals, fostering private sector engagement in gender equality, applying a social and economic justice lens to sustainable finance, and improving accountability in gender-responsive investing.

This *Case Studies Series* showcases approaches which were led by UN Women to channel financing toward gender equality and women’s empowerment (GEWE) at the global, regional and national levels. These innovative efforts respond to the urgent need to mobilize additional financial resources to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and to bridge the estimated US$420 billion annual financing gap for gender equality across developing countries.

THE CASE STUDIES APPROACH

This compendium highlights case studies demonstrating UN Women's work with governments, development partners, financial institutions, private sector entities and civil society organizations. It highlights diverse initiatives from the global, regions and countries at various development stages.

These examples showcase the potential of private capital to advance gender equality and call on businesses to innovate gender-responsive solutions, engaging them as essential partners in achieving the SDGs and GEWE.

Acknowledging the evolving nature of sustainable finance, this compendium presents best practices and lessons in key areas:

I. **Raising awareness and enabling environments:** Working with government entities, knowledge partners and financial authorities, UN Women fosters awareness and creates environments conducive to gender-focused financing.

II. **Stakeholder dialogue platforms:** Stakeholders exchange knowledge and cross-fertilize innovations in the gender-responsive finance ecosystem through collaborative forums.

III. **Standards and accountability in sustainable finance:** Collaborating with standard-setting organizations, UN Women advances clarity and accountability in gender-responsive finance standards, frameworks and toolkits.

IV. **Showcasing innovative finance instruments:** To demonstrate proof of concept, UN Women introduces countries and markets to impactful, gender-focused financial tools and approaches, in partnership with governments, corporations and financial institutions.

Photo: Shuttersotck

RAISING AWARENESS AND CREATING ENABLING ENVIRONMENTS

Working with government entities, knowledge partners and financial authorities, UN Women fosters awareness and creates environments conducive to gender-focused financing

GLOBAL INITIATIVE
THE FINANCE IN COMMON GENDER COALITION

Public Development Banks (PDBs) have been established by governments at the regional, national and multinational levels. They are designed to actively advance the goals of public policy. Their mandates are often focused on mobilizing financial resources for investments that address social and environmental needs unmet by the market. They are therefore inherently positioned to play a critical role in advancing the SDGs.

Global context

Finance in Common (FiCS) is a global network of PDBs dedicated to aligning financial resources with the goals of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development and the Paris Agreement. The FiCS movement encompasses over 530 PDBs from some 154 economies, managing approximately US$23 trillion in assets and US$2.5 trillion in annual investments, which is more than 10 per cent of the total public and private investment flows.[1] The FiCS initiative is organized around 13 thematic coalitions of PDBs and partners, including the largest and longest-running being focused on gender equality and women's empowerment (GEWE), chaired by UN Women as the permanent anchor.

Approach

Since 2020, UN Women has played a pivotal leadership role as the permanent anchor chair of the FiCS Gender Coalition, partnering annually with a rotating co-chair from a different PDB. The coalition brings together 89 development banks and partners through regular meetings to share expertise and best practices. It unites PDBs and stakeholders to address financial and development challenges, with a strong focus on Sustainable Development Goal 5 (SDG 5). The coalition demonstrates a collective commitment to scaling up gender-focused initiatives, sharing innovative approaches, and exchanging insights across diverse regions and institutional mandates.

In 2021, UN Women with the co-chair the Agence Française de Développement (AFD), developed the Public Development Banks Driving Gender Equality report.

In 2022, with the goal of boosting accountability, funding and the integration of gender in climate goals, UN Women and the African Development Bank convened monthly discussions, a high-level forum on gender and climate finance, and a Women CEOs Breakfast in parallel to the FiCS 2022 Summit. These events aimed to review the achievements of the FiCS Gender Coalition and women's empowerment in development banks, explore financing for gender equality, and provided a valuable networking opportunity for high-level professionals.

Activities in 2023 included enhancing women's financial inclusion and improving access to finance for women-owned small and medium-sized enterprises. A joint survey and report with the Inter-American Development Bank highlighted achievements, opportunities and challenges in women's financial inclusion. Additionally, 30 PDBs joined the FiCS Gender Coalition, with two signing onto the Paris Development Banks' statement on GEWE.[2]

In 2024, UN Women and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) co-chaired the FiCS Gender Coalition. The selected theme of collaboration in 2024 focused on financing care infrastructure. A knowledge product showcases emerging PDB-led care projects aimed at increasing investment in care infrastructure and services to promote GEWE.

Results

Since the launch of the FiCS Gender Coalition, UN Women has been supporting a dynamic collaboration model, advancing both continuity and fresh perspectives on gender issues pertinent to PDBs and the global financing for gender equality agenda.

The FiCS Gender Coalition has strengthend PDBs' under standing, commitments and actions to advance GEWE. The first global summit—the 2020 Finance in Common Summit held in November 2020 in Paris—resulted in the adoption of a groundbreaking Statement on Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment, initially signed by 25 development banks.

Under UN Women's co-chairing since 2020, a total of 44 signatories (as of the FiCS Summit 2023) have signed the Paris Development Banks statement on Gender Equality and Women's Empowerment. The growing adoption of this statement highlights increased recognition among PDBs of the importance of integrating a gender equality focus into all levels of financing, from policies to project implementation. The FiCS Gender Coalition's goals include increasing gender-focused funding, creating gender equality strategies, and aligning gender equality with climate and biodiversity goals. For example, UN Women's tracking has revealed that since signing the statement, seven PDBs have raised capital, which is exclusively or partially for gender-focused investments via sustainable bond issuances; they mobilized over US$21 billion between 2020 and the end of 2023.

CONCLUSION

PDBs are uniquely positioned to drive GEWE through innovative financing solutions and collaborative initiatives. The FiCS Gender Coalition, led by UN Women, unites global actors to integrate gender equality into development finance, ensuring inclusive, sustainable progress towards the 2030 Agenda and SDG 5.

In collaboration with:

Photo: UN Women / Ryan Brown

II STAKEHOLDER DIALOGUE PLATFORMS

Through collaborative forums, stakeholders exchange knowledge and cross-fertilize innovations in the gender-responsive finance ecosystem

CHINA
GENDER FINANCE LANDSCAPE ANALYSIS

Gender finance landscape analysis provides an overview of the key stakeholders and existing financial sources contributing to advancing GEWE. It aims to raise awareness among governmental authorities and stakeholders on aligning national priorities and financial systems with gender equality goals. The landscape analysis serves as an essential first step in identifying gaps, opportunities and necessary interventions to advance gender-responsive financing in countries.

Country context

In China, gender equality is a fundamental national development priority. The country has integrated women's rights into its legal framework, with policies supporting women's entrepreneurship, employment and combating discrimination. The China National Program for Women's Development 2021–2030 sets strategic goals for women's economic advancement, supported by the Ministry of Finance and the People's Bank of China through fiscal policies and market innovation.

Sustainable financing for GEWE (or "gender finance") is emerging as a critical means in China to support women's sustainable development. While China has made significant strides in green finance, totalling US$2.3 trillion according to the Union Bank of Switzerland (UBS), comparable data on social finance, particularly gender finance, remain limited. A clear definition of gender finance is still lacking, reflecting ongoing challenges in developing gender-responsive financial policies, strategies and instruments in China.

Scaling up resources from both public and private sources, along with diverse financing instruments, is crucial for sustainable development and gender equality. Despite policy advancements and increased recognition of gender finance, challenges persist. Addressing them requires more than just access to funds—it calls for overcoming biases, tailoring instruments for vulnerable groups, building capacity and fostering supportive financial ecosystems.

Approach

In 2023, UN Women commissioned the International Institute of Green Finance (IIGF) to conduct a landscape analysis on gender finance development in China. The landscape mapped out key stakeholders for the development of gender finance in China, such as governmental bodies, financial institutions, NGOs and research institutes, and identified existing gender-responsive financial policies, initiatives and instruments. It provided a preliminary view of gaps and opportunities that require further exploration to support sustainable financing for GEWE in China. Building on the insights from the landscape analysis, UN Women has organized policy dialogues and stakeholder consultations and convened industry events to further raise awareness of gender-responsive sustainable finance.

Photo: UN Women China Office. Roundtable with stakeholders in Chinese financial market in Beijing, China, January 2024.

Results

The landscape analysis identified gaps in gender awareness and provided an evidence base to inform capacity development needs for knowledge-sharing salons and workshops to raise awareness and build knowledge on gender-responsive financing among key stakeholders in China's financial sector. In 2024, five workshops and training sessions were held to advance awareness and capacity development to facilitate discussions on gender-responsive financial practices among select stakeholders.

The landscape analysis laid the foundation for a strategic five-year memorandum of understanding (MoU) with the IIGF (under the Central University of Finance and Economics). Signed in September 2024, this MoU supports public and private sector efforts in advancing the development of gender-responsive financing policies, strategies and instruments.

UN Women now serves as a strategic gender advisory partner to IIGF and chairs a technical group on financing for women's sustainable development within the China Green Finance Committee (GFC), which is attached to the Central Bank – People's Bank of China. It is the first research group of its kind focusing on gender finance within a financial regulatory policy body. In November 2024, UN Women started new research to explore the integration of gender considerations in environmental, social and government (ESG) frameworks across key financial subsectors in China, focusing on state-owned and joint-stock banks.

The landscape analysis also identified opportunities to map and engage multilateral development banks (MDBs) and private equity and venture capital (PEVC) firms to mainstream gender considerations in their project financing and investment decisions, with new funding secured from the Ford Foundation to support new portfolios.

CONCLUSION

A landscape assessment provided a foundational understanding of the current gender finance landscape in China, highlighting areas where strategic interventions can support gender equality goals. By identifying key stakeholders, existing gaps and emerging opportunities, the landscape assessment serves as a critical starting point for future work in developing gender-responsive financial frameworks in the country.

The insights from the landscape assessment can also lay the groundwork for UN Women to convene both dialogues and collaboration across the public and private sectors, to then expand awareness and understanding of China's specific financing issues beyond financial experts and include a broader network of policymakers and stakeholders invested in gender-responsive financing.

In collaboration with: IIGF 中央财经大学绿色金融国际研究院 INTERNATIONAL INSTITUTE OF GREEN FINANCE

Photo: UN Women / Christopher Herwig

III STANDARDS AND ACCOUNTABILITY IN SUSTAINABLE FINANCE

Collaborating with standard-setting organizations, UN Women advances clarity and accountability in gender-responsive finance standards, frameworks and toolkits

GLOBAL INITIATIVE

DEVELOPING A GUIDE TO DESIGN AND ISSUE GENDER BONDS

With declining ODA for gender equality, it is increasingly important to mobilize diverse resources—both public and private—to drive gender equality goals. Sustainable debt instruments align financial assets with sustainability objectives, offering long-term, inclusive growth opportunities.

Global context

The sustainable capital market has seen impressive growth, with green bonds at the forefront. Since its inception in 2007, the green bond market reached US$1 trillion in cumulative issuances by 2020.[3] This momentum has sparked growth in other sustainable debt instruments, including bonds, loans and sukuk, across 67 countries and supranational institutions.

By 2023, Europe led the market in sustainable debt, accounting for 46 per cent of issuances, followed by Asia and the Pacific (33 per cent), North America (11 per cent) and Latin America and the Caribbean (6 per cent). Despite Africa representing only 1 per cent of the total, it achieved notable growth in aligned green bond issuances.[4]

However, gender bonds remain underdeveloped; only 1 per cent of sustainable bonds in 2022 directly aligned with SDG 5 on gender equality.[5] This highlights a gap: how can capital markets be leveraged to address structural gender inequalities through sustainable bonds?

Approach

Recognizing the risk of "pinkwashing"—where bonds are labelled as promoting gender equality without genuine impact—UN Women took action to drive meaningful change in the gender bond space. In 2021, UN Women partnered with the International Capital Market Association (ICMA) and International Finance Corporation (IFC) to publish *Bonds to Bridge the Gender Gap: A Practitioner's Guide to Using Sustainable Debt for Gender Equality*. This guide, the first of its kind, provides a framework for integrating gender equality objectives into sustainable debt products, using ICMA's Social Bond Principles and targeting SDG 5. Importantly, it encourages verification from independent entities to enhance credibility and transparency.

Since the publication of this Guide, UN Women and its partners actively promoted the dissemination through industry gatherings, fostering a deeper understanding of gender bonds among market stakeholders in both developed and emerging economies. This outreach raised awareness of social, sustainability and sustainability-linked bonds and underscored the potential for channelling capital towards gender equality initiatives.

Building on the experience of advancing global guidance, UN Women has also emphasized support in less developed markets, collaborating with Financial Sector Deepening (FSD) Africa to build local capacity. Through initiatives like feasibility research and gender bond market analysis, UN Women has been instrumental in increasing Africa's engagement with gender bonds.

Together with FSD Africa, UN Women conducted and introduced the *Viability of Gender Bonds in SSA: A Landscape Analysis and Feasibility Assessment* to issuers and investors, followed by technical support by FSD Africa to regulators and interested issuers. Gender bonds have now entered the market.

Photo: FSD Africa, Gender Bond Toolkit Dissemination Event in Lusaka, Zambia, June 2024.

In partnership with FSD Africa, the FSD Network Gender Collaborative Programme (FSD Network) and British International Investment (BII), UN Women developed *Gender Bonds: A Toolkit for the Design and Issuance of Gender Bonds in Africa*, published in February 2024. Training sessions in Kenya, Zambia and Nigeria equipped potential issuers, financial institutions and investors with practical tools to implement gender bonds. FSD Africa's regional expertise combined with BII's investment experience complemented UN Women's expertise and experience in gender equality, ensuring the toolkit resonated with the African context.

Results

The gender bond guide has seen widespread adoption, helping investors and issuers develop sustainable financing frameworks that include gender equality expenditure categories. With UN Women's technical advisory, countries including Colombia, Egypt and Iceland have leveraged the guide to integrate gender considerations into sovereign financing frameworks.

Africa has also seen growing interest in gender bonds through awareness campaigns, regulatory guidelines and sovereign sustainable debt frameworks. These efforts are setting the stage for a robust gender bond market in the region.

CONCLUSION

Through collaborations with development finance institutions, governments and knowledge partners, UN Women is linking financial markets and gender equality. By developing tools and providing technical advisory, UN Women supports the growth of accountable and transparent gender-focused finance instruments, ultimately advancing the global gender equality agenda in meaningful ways.

LUXEMBOURG

LUXEMBOURG STOCK EXCHANGE PROMOTING GENDER-FOCUSED BONDS

Gender bonds are an innovative financing tool aimed at accelerating progress towards gender equality by channelling investment into projects that support women's empowerment, in line with SDG 5. These bonds can be used to fund various initiatives, such as loans for women-owned businesses and services for survivors of gender-based violence. They mobilize private capital, focusing on key gender equality objectives, including closing the gender pay gap and investing in care systems. Gender bonds are a strategic method to achieve meaningful, measurable social impact.

Country context

Luxembourg is at the forefront of leveraging and capitalizing emerging opportunities in sustainable finance. As a globally recognized hub for sustainable finance, it actively supports, drives, and fosters gender-focused financial initiatives, advancing women's empowerment and equality in the process. Bourse de Luxembourg (Luxembourg Stock Exchange or LuxSE) is the world's leading listing venue for the listing of international debt securities. The Luxembourg Green Exchange (LGX) launched by LuxSE, one of the world's largest platforms for sustainable securities, introduced a new flagship initiative highlighting securities that allocate financing specifically to projects and strategies advancing gender equality and SDG 5, making it easier for investors to identify and support initiatives dedicated to women's empowerment.

Approach

In 2022, recognizing the need for greater visibility of sustainable bonds raising capital for GEWE projects, UN Women collaborated with the LuxSE to promote joint initiatives to advance financing for GEWE.

To facilitate global tracking and a greater understanding of gender bonds, UN Women and LuxSE developed definitions and methodologies, including periodic reviews of gender bonds displayed on the LGX and in international markets. As part of its collaboration with UN Women, LuxSE leveraged the LGX Academy to actively promote and raise awareness of gender finance, coordinating efforts with relevant institutions in Luxembourg to strengthen the link between finance and gender equality.

Results

The partnership between UN Women and LuxSE has driven significant advancements in gender finance through innovative tools, increased transparency and influencing industry standards. As part of this collaboration, UN Women and LuxSE launched a case study series, developing practical fact sheets on bonds issued by various organizations aimed at narrowing gender gaps. The series highlights a range of innovative financial tools introduced across developed and emerging markets, all focused on promoting gender equality through financial strategies. To date, the publication has been downloaded over 3,000 times from UN Women's website.

In a further step towards market transparency, live extracts from the LGX database are now published on the ICMA Sustainable Bond Market Data webpage, providing real-time insights into the growth of the gender theme in the sustainable finance market.

More than 500 new bond issuances tagged for SDG 5 have been recorded since the market's inception, reflecting a growing commitment from issuers to implement gender equality projects. These data enhance visibility and accessibility, fostering greater interest and engagement with gender-responsive bonds from investors.

UN Women and LuxSE also co-organized a masterclass on gender finance at the United Nations Climate Change Conference COP28. This capacity-building event focused on harnessing capital markets to promote global gender equality and empower women. Through interactive dialogue on challenges in gender-focused finance and the connections between gender and climate finance, participants engaged with expert speakers on current initiatives that drive financing for women's and girls' empowerment.

In 2024, UN Women became a member of two working groups of the Luxembourg Gender Finance Task Force, convened by the Ministry of Finance to foster strategic development within Luxembourg's financial ecosystem. LuxSE chairs two working groups within the Task Force, with UN Women serving as a key member, actively contributing to defining gender finance standards and driving innovations. These efforts are instrumental in integrating gender finance within Luxembourg's financial sector and creating a replicable model for other global markets.

CONCLUSION

Gender bonds are revolutionizing sustainable finance by channelling investments into impactful projects that advance GEWE. The partnership between UN Women and the Luxembourg Stock Exchange is innovative and drives transparency and is helping to develop market standards and foster global engagement. These efforts underline the potential of a gender-focused bond market to create meaningful, measurable social impact and accelerate progress towards SDG 5.

In collaboration with:

LUXEMBOURG GREEN EXCHANGE

COLOMBIA
FRAMEWORK FOR SOVEREIGN GREEN, SOCIAL AND SUSTAINABLE BONDS

A sustainable finance framework—often referred to as a securities or debt framework—provides clear definitions of activities and projects that qualify towards an organization's sustainable finance commitments. The framework serves as a critical tool for promoting growth in sustainable investments by fostering transparency and accountability. Establishing a sustainable finance framework that incorporates gender dimensions is a crucial step for borrowers to effectively tap into the evolving market with increasing interest in investing in gender outcomes. For organizations, adopting and implementing such a framework also enhances risk management, sustainability credentials and more robust data for sustainability reporting.

Country context

Colombia has made significant progress over the past two decades in advancing gender equality, driven by robust legislative frameworks and public policies aimed at promoting women's rights and addressing gender-based violence. However, challenges such as persistent inequality and poverty remain, exacerbated by the impacts of the COVID-19 pandemic.

According to 2023 data from the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), only 48 per cent of women and girls aged 15 to 64 were employed in 2021, compared to nearly 74 per cent of men, resulting in a 26-percentage-point gender employment gap, 12 points higher than the OECD average.[6] Moreover, these national statistics mask stark regional disparities. In some rural areas, the gender gap in labour force participation is more than double that of urban centres. The UNDP Multidimensional Poverty Index indicates that 40.6 per cent of the population experiences high levels of deprivation.[7]

Data have also shown that women's unpaid care responsibilities are significantly high in Colombia, where women spend 22 more hours per week in unpaid care work than men do, who spend 23 hours per week more than women do on paid work activities.[8] The differences in rates are especially wide in rural areas, where access to basic infrastructure, education and childcare services are comparatively poor compared to those in urban areas. Other challenges include traditional social norms and the unique needs of Indigenous communities. These factors not only limit women's income but also hinder their personal development, with the full impact yet to be quantified.

Approach

To leverage the rapid growth in sustainable finance which presents opportunities for new investment in gender outcomes, the Government of Colombia introduced in 2022 a sustainable financing framework that includes eligible gender equality expenditures and project categories. This process was supported by UN Women, which provided technical support to the Government of Colombia represented by the Office of the Vice President (2018–2022). This led to the sovereign framework and particularly the development and implementation of financing solutions for sustainable development, through the issuance, management and non-binding monitoring of the impact of bonds aligned with the objectives of gender equality and women's empowerment; a selection of eligible gender equality expenditure and project categories; and various recommendations for improvement. The Framework for Sovereign Green, Social and Sustainable Bonds of Colombia includes a few social categories that address gender inequality and the empowerment of women, including occupational training, education, access to healthcare and respect for the human rights of vulnerable populations.

Results

On 5 August 2022, in its National Development Plan 2018–2022 Pact for Colombia, Pact for Equity, the Government of Colombia published the Colombia Sovereign Green Bond Framework with eligible gender equality expenditure and project categories, a step closer to the issuance of a sovereign gender bond.

CONCLUSION

Colombia's integration of gender dimensions into its sustainable finance framework marks a significant step forward in promoting gender equality and empowering women through innovative financing solutions. By aligning its national development priorities with sustainable investment strategies, Colombia has set a benchmark for leveraging sovereign green, social and sustainable bonds to address deep-rooted gender inequalities.

This initiative reinforces the country's commitment to sustainable development and highlights the transformative potential of sustainable finance in reducing gender gaps and fostering economic resilience. Colombia's framework stands out as an inspiring model for other nations seeking to incorporate gender considerations into sustainable financing, advancing a more equitable and sustainable future.

PAKISTAN

IMPROVING ESG REGULATION AND ACTION TO PROMOTE SUSTAINABLE BUSINESS AND CAPITAL MARKETS

Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) practices have become essential for promoting sustainability in business and capital markets. ESG frameworks ensure that companies commit to sustainable business practices, including gender equality, which is a fundamental aspect of ESG's social dimension.

Country context

In Pakistan, significant gender disparities, such as limited access to financial resources and decision-making roles, have impeded women's empowerment and broader development outcomes. Women face challenges in accessing property, inheritance and financial services. Female owned accounts constituted only 25 per cent of the total number of bank account holders.[9] This gap in financial inclusion, coupled with a lack of gender diversity in the financial sector, especially in decision-making roles,[10] calls for a more robust and gender-responsive ESG ecosystem in Pakistan.

Pakistan faces several challenges in implementing ESG practices. Limited awareness and understanding of ESG principles hinder their widespread adoption. Data availability and transparency, particularly on gender diversity, remain poor, making accountability difficult. Cultural norms and gender biases further impede progress on gender-related ESG goals. Moreover, many businesses lack the financial and technical capacity to integrate ESG standards, and limited access to ESG-focused financial instruments constrains investment in sustainability efforts, slowing overall progress towards a robust ESG ecosystem.

Approach

UN Women has played an active role in capitalizing on Pakistan's growing momentum towards innovative approaches and creating pathways for gender-responsive investments. Efforts included supporting development of a transparent and effective ESG ecosystem that promotes sustainable business practices, especially those that empower women.

Collaborating with the SECP—the Securities and Exchange Commission of Pakistan—the regulator of the capital market and the corporate sector, insurance sector and non-banking finance companies in Pakistan, UN Women supported the market advancement of gender-sensitive ESG frameworks and actions. As part of this initiative, UN Women contributed to the SECP's ESG Regulatory Roadmap, which encourages companies to integrate ESG information in their reporting processes, promotes transparency in corporate governance and emphasizes the inclusion of gender equality metrics.

Another key milestone was supporting the introduction of Guidelines on ESG Disclosures for Listed Companies (2023), encouraging companies to voluntarily report on their ESG activities with a strong emphasis on gender equality. UN Women successfully advocated for the inclusion of the Women's Empowerment Principles (WEPs) in the guidelines. The guidelines encourage businesses to disclose their efforts in promoting gender diversity, inclusion and equality in the workplace, including policies on women's representation in leadership, gender pay equity and gender-responsive work environments.

UN Women also supported the development and operationalization of ESG Sustain, an interactive online platform aimed at availability and reporting of sustainability-related disclosures and information to all stakeholders. Launched in 2024, this platform promotes responsible business practices by encouraging environmental stewardship, social equity and inclusive governance in Pakistan, serving as a catalyst for enhancing investor confidence and transparency.

UN Women has also played a pivotal role in convening stakeholders to foster dialogue and collaboration on ESG-based investments. In 2024, UN Women and SECP jointly hosted an ESG symposium titled 'Driving Progress on Sustainability and Climate Change' in Karachi, Pakistan. The discussions focused on a range of subjects including the role of gender equality in sustainable investing and responsible business practices, a review of ESG Sustain as a sustainability-related information portal, and the WEPs as an effective framework for GEWE in driving sustainability. By bringing together a diverse range of stakeholders, the event highlighted the need for continued collaboration between regulators, financial institutions and the private sector to promote sustainable investments that prioritize women's empowerment.

Results

The collaboration between UN Women and SECP has enhanced the visibility of gender equality within Pakistan's capital markets. Since 2022, the Pakistan Stock Exchange (PSX) has encouraged listed companies to report on ESG compliance, particularly focusing on women's empowerment. The inclusion of gender equality as one of the seven minimum SDGs for PSX's top 25 companies' awards has further elevated the importance of social responsibility in Pakistan's business landscape.

The launch of the ESG Sustain portal enable companies to better integrate gender-responsive practices into their business models and sustainability reporting.

Photo: UN Women Pakistan Office. Launch of ESG Sustain in Islamabad, Pakistan, 2024.

Through the ESG Sustain portal, companies can report their progress on these fronts, ensuring transparency and accountability while helping investors and stakeholders track advancements in gender diversity. Both initiatives aim to foster more inclusive corporate environments in Pakistan, driving sustainable development with a focus on gender equality.

Moreover, working closely with the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP), UN Women has also helped the implementation of gender-responsive policies including the Banking on Equality Policy, which enhances women's financial inclusion. UN Women has also promoted capacity-building in the private sector, focusing on gender-responsive procurement, budgeting and human resources policies. The adoption of the WEPs by private sector companies has further driven inclusive economic growth.

CONCLUSION

UN Women has played a key role in advancing women's economic empowerment in Pakistan by collaborating with financial regulators and institutions. By supporting ESG regulation and initiatives with bodies including the Securities and Exchange Commission of Pakistan, UN Women has fostered a more transparent and inclusive ESG ecosystem, promoting gender equality, sustainable investments and responsible governance.

In collaboration with:

SECP

MEXICO

THE WORLD'S FIRST SUSTAINABLE FINANCE TAXONOMY WITH GENDER EQUALITY AS A PRIORITY OBJECTIVE

Sustainable finance taxonomies have emerged as a key policy tool in global efforts to classify assets, activities or projects deemed "sustainable" based on environmental and social objectives, guiding capital towards sustainable sectors. Including gender equality as a priority ensures financial resources support gender-focused initiatives. By incorporating gender impact metrics, taxonomies hold stakeholders accountable, advancing social equity alongside environmental and economic goals for more inclusive and sustainable outcomes.

Country context

Mexico has made substantial progress on gender equality over the years, but worldwide, the country ranks 33rd in terms of its gender gap, trailing other Latin American and Caribbean nations.[11] Women play vital roles in household income, food security and natural resource management, yet they face barriers in accessing land, capital and technology, limiting their economic empowerment.[12] For instance, 46 per cent of women in Mexico lack access to credit compared to 40 per cent of men, and in localities with fewer than 15,000 inhabitants, only 20 per cent of women have formal credit versus 23 per cent of men.[13] The gender gap in labour force participation is among the highest in the OECD and Latin America, standing at 32 per cent in 2021, far above the OECD average of 13.5 per cent and the LA5 average of 23 per cent. The LA5 are the five major economies of Latin America: Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Mexico and Peru. Wage disparities persist, with a gender gap of 14 per cent, slightly above the OECD average of 11.9 per cent. Although Mexico's informal employment sector is large, employing over half of the workforce, the gender gap in informal employment is relatively small at about 2 per cent. Additionally, the educational attainment gender gap is relatively narrow compared to OECD averages.[14]

Mexico recognizes the critical importance of addressing gender disparities and empowering women economically. It has adopted gender-responsive policy measures, including one of the most advanced gender-responsive budgeting systems globally. The Ministry of Finance and Public Credit (SHCP) has published guidelines to integrate gender perspectives into financial institutions. Moreover, the Trust Funds for Rural Development (FIRA) issued a social bond in 2020 focused on gender, aiming to increase financing for women-led projects in rural areas, showcasing a commitment to advancing women's economic empowerment.

Approach

In 2023, Mexico achieved a significant milestone by launching the world's first taxonomy to prioritize gender equality as a social objective. Mexico's taxonomy issued by SHCP aims to respond to the most relevant social and environmental challenges in the country by helping to channel finance towards projects and activities that address them.

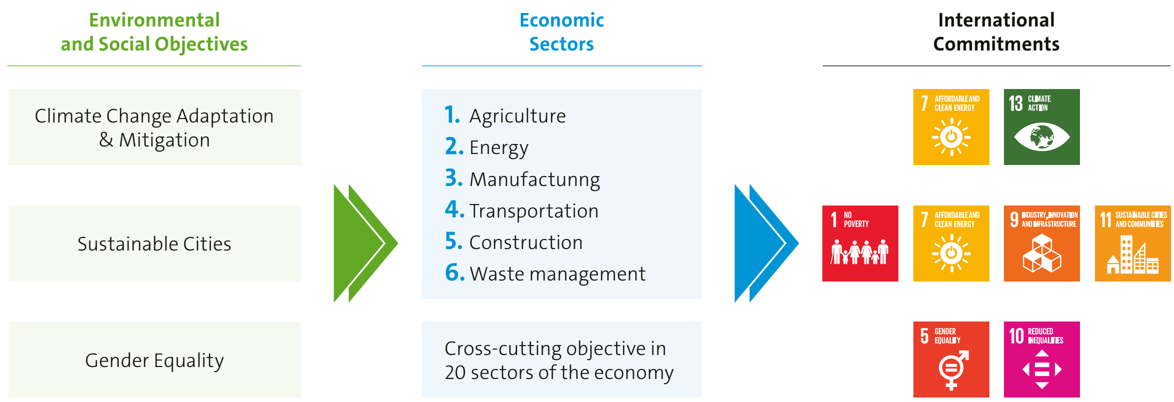
Alongside climate change, it identifies poverty and inequality as two such challenges, noting that the levels of poverty and inequality in Mexico have remained above the levels of other countries in Latin America. Gender gaps are specifically identified as a persistent inequality across both rural and urban areas. On this basis, Mexico's taxonomy defines three main objectives: climate change (mitigation and adaptation), gender equality and sustainable cities, and it lays out criteria to assess the contribution of economic activities to each of these objectives.[15]

UN Women contributed to the development of the Mexican Sustainable Taxonomy. UN Women served as a member of the Thematic Technical Group focused on gender equality within the Mexican Sustainable Taxonomy and which developed the approach for the gender equality objective. The Thematic Technical Group was led by the National Women's Institute of Mexico and had participation of experts from the Inter-American Development Bank (IDB), Banco de México (Bank of Mexico or Banxico), FIRA, SHCP, Banco Nacional de Obras y Servicios Públicos (National Works and Public Services Bank or BANOBRAS), Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (German International Cooperation Society or GIZ) and World Resources Institute (WRI) México, among other institutions, alongside UN Women.

Together, the Technical Group developed technical evaluation criteria that enable the identification of investments that contribute to closing gender gaps in Mexico. This includes a Gender Equality Index to assess companies' and investment projects' contribution to gender equality for employees, consumers and communities. The Gender Gap Analysis Tool based on WEPs were taken up, which aims to support private sector organizations in assessing their practice in terms of policies, mechanisms and strategies related to three pillars of gender equality: decent work, well-being and social inclusion. A clear list of 43 questions with a total of

FIGURE 1

LINKING ECONOMIC SECTORS WITH THE OBJECTIVES OF THE TAXONOMY AND INTERNATIONAL COMMITMENTS



Source: Mexican Sustainable Taxonomy 2023.

174 points for three pillars of gender equality serves as a best practice guide for users to ensure that organizations undertake economic activities that support gender equality. For instance, criteria for decent work include equal pay, equal access and labour development, care and co-responsibility (66 points); criteria for well-being includes the promotion of equal access to goods and services, health with a gender quality perspective, economic and social empowerment (54 points); and social inclusion is a criterion on its own (54 points). To be eligible, activities should reach a minimum of 72 points.[16]

The Index is sector agnostic, recognizing that gender equality objectives are relevant across all sectors of the Mexican economy. Because the index is not tied to any one sector, it can serve as a tool for gender equality objectives to be mainstreamed across other goals, environmental and/or social.

Results

The Mexican Sustainable Taxonomy is a world-first taxonomy that defines gender equality as a priority objective, encouraging investment in businesses that are closing gender gaps. The Ministry of Finance has developed an online course for how to use it. The course provides an overview of the Mexican Sustainable Taxonomy as a financial public policy instrument for sustainability and its potential applications for prospective user institutions. The Mexican Sustainable Taxonomy serves as a vital tool for corporates, financial institutions, institutional investors and government agencies, fostering alignment between sustainable finance practices and national priorities.

CONCLUSION

With its currently voluntary nature, the Taxonomy provides stakeholders with the flexibility to gradually integrate its principles into their sustainable finance strategies, which aligns with global trends, where most taxonomies have effectively guided market behaviour despite being non-mandatory. Beyond promoting public investment in sustainable projects, the Taxonomy can act as a catalyst for the growth of Mexico's sustainable finance market, mobilizing consistent investment flows from both the public and private sectors. As the second taxonomy launched in Latin America, after Colombia, Mexico's framework serves as an important regional benchmark, particularly for its emphasis on integrating social objectives alongside environmental goals.

In collaboration with:

Photo: Shuttersock

IV SHOWCASING INNOVATIVE FINANCE INSTRUMENTS

Demonstrating proof of concept, UN Women introduces countries and markets to impactful, gender-focused financial tools and approaches, in partnership with governments, corporations and financial institutions

REGIONAL INITIATIVE

ASIA

EMPOWERING WOMEN-OWNED BUSINESSES AND SUPPORTING BUSINESSES TO BE GENDER-RESPONSIVE

Women-owned businesses drive countries' economic growth. When women are given equal opportunities and access to resources, their contributions significantly enhance societal capacity. Empowering women through gender-smart investing unlocks their potential as entrepreneurs and leaders, creating transformative change that benefits both the economy and communities. Moreover, all businesses can be encouraged and supported to develop gender-responsive practices.

Regional context

While the Asia region has experienced remarkable socioeconomic growth, this progress has not been evenly distributed. Gender inequality remains a persistent challenge. According to the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2021, it will take 195.4 years to close the gender gap in South Asia and 165 years in East Asia and the Pacific.

Despite the increasing number of women-owned businesses—nearly 6 million formal businesses in the region—female entrepreneurs continue to face barriers which are significant. In countries like Indonesia, where 85 per cent of women-owned businesses are small-scale, many women lack access to critical assets such as land ownership.[17] In India, 70 per cent of women-led businesses were underfunded,[18] while in China, about 55 per cent of new Internet businesses were being founded by women, but women entrepreneurs often struggled with limited start-up capital more than men.[19] Societal norms further exacerbate these challenges by discour-aging women from entering high-growth sectors or leadership positions.

Approach

Recognizing the vital role of women in socioeconomic development, UN Women, with support from the European Union, launched WeEmpowerAsia to promote gender-equal business opportunities in China, India, Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, Thailand and Viet Nam. The programme focuses on increasing women's participation and leadership in the private sector to drive inclusive growth and building more gender-responsive businesses and value chains in selected sectors, such as the fashion and textile sector. Efforts focus on creating a conducive business environment, promoting women-owned businesses and advancing gender-inclusive cultures through the WEPs.

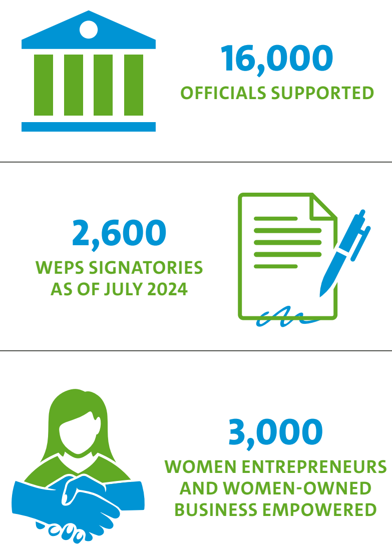
A critical tool developed through WeEmpowerAsia is the WeRise Toolkit, which supports Asian women entrepreneurs, accelerators and financial institutions to implement more gender-responsive practices.

- The **WeRise Toolkit for Entrepreneurs** offers practical tools, guidance and training in areas such as business planning, marketing, financial literacy and leadership, helping women overcome barriers such as limited access to finance.
- The **WeRise Toolkit for Accelerators** guides incubators in creating gender-responsive programmes that enhance support for women entrepreneurs through mentorship, networks and resources. It encourages accelerators to integrate gender considerations in their operations, from recruitment to programme delivery. Both toolkits have adopted gender-sensitive approaches, recognizing the unique challenges women entrepreneurs face, such as access to finance and balancing business with household responsibilities.
- The **WeRise Finance Maps** provide information on loans, grants and Investments. They help women access capital and bridge the gender finance gap. This holistic approach has fostered a more inclusive entrepreneurial environment across Asia, and has strengthened the capacities of women-led businesses and driven gender-responsive economic growth.

- The COVID-19 pandemic intensified the challenges for women in the workforce, particularly in the care economy. In response, UN Women launched the **Care Accelerator** under the **WeEmpowerAsia** initiative to support women entrepreneurs in the care sector. This accelerator provided tools, resources and mentorship to scale up businesses in areas including childcare, aged care and healthcare. By empowering women-led ventures in these essential services, the initiative not only helped ease caregiving burdens but also provided small grants and access to networks, enabling businesses to thrive in the face of the pandemic's economic disruptions.

Results

Through the WeEmpowerAsia programme, more than 16,000 officials from public, private and civil society organizations in Asia and the Pacific were supported through providing information or trainings relating to women's economic empowerment and gender equality, with 1,757 companies signing the WEPs (there were 588 signatory companies at the start of the programme). This increase in signatories has continued beyond WeEmpower Asia, with nearly 2,600 signatories as of July 2024 and the potential to impact at least 5.2 million employees. The programme also provided training and resources to more than 3,000 women entrepreneurs and women-owned business, equipping them with skills in leadership, finance and digital technologies to help scale up their businesses.



In relation to policy advocacy, the initiative fostered dialogues between government agencies and civil society, promoting gender-smart investing and gender-inclusive business practices and leadership, particularly in sectors with high female representation, such as small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs).

During the COVID-19 crisis, the programme provided targeted support to several women-led businesses through online training in digital literacy and access to e-commerce platforms, helping them navigate and withstand the economic challenges brought by the pandemic. More than 8,340 people participated in events that aimed to increase access to entrepreneurship and leadership training programmes.

Incubated initiatives of WeEmpower Asia formed the stepping stone for scaling up and deepening work with the private sector through, for example, the WE RISE Together programme, which aims to facilitate more equal market opportunities for women entrepreneurs by advancing gender-responsive procurement in the Mekong subregion (WEPs Principle 5) and the Gender-Inclusive Care Entrepreneurship Ecosystem Program (GICEEP).

CONCLUSION

WeEmpowerAsia has created a collaborative environment between the private sector and policymakers, ensuring women remain central to economic recovery and growth. By encouraging businesses and investment to implement gender-inclusive strategies, the programme has contributed significantly to advancing women's economic empowerment and promoting gender equality in Asia's business sector.

In collaboration with:

Funded by the European Union

weempowerasia
Gender equality means good business

REGIONAL INITIATIVE

AFRICA, CENTRAL AMERICA AND THE CARIBBEAN

THE BUY FROM WOMEN INITIATIVE

E-commerce is a powerful tool for promoting gender equality and advancing women's economic empowerment. It provides women with greater access to markets, capital and flexible opportunities, while breaking down traditional barriers linked to gender-based discrimination, mobility and financial exclusion. By leveraging these tools, women can take greater control of their economic futures, leading to more inclusive and equitable growth globally.

The Buy from Women initiative is an open-sourced, cloud-based enterprise and e-commerce platform, developed by UN Women, available both through the web and an app and delivered in multiple languages. It is customizable for any business processes in local ecosystems, where women entrepreneurs and business holders can have easier access to additional markets, information and finance. The platform can accommodate any commodities and provides essential digital infrastructure to various economic empowerment programmes. It also generates rich data to enhance decision making and profitability.

LIBERIA

Country context

Liberian women face significant challenges rooted in high poverty rates estimated at around 44 per cent, alongside pervasive gender inequality and limited infrastructure.[20] These factors create substantial barriers to women's economic empowerment. With more than half of Liberia's population living below the poverty line and the country ranking 164th out of 191 on the Gender Inequality Index,[21] the struggle for equality is significant.

Challenges in access to education, healthcare and economic opportunities, including limited access to credit and banking services, as well as minimal social protections and insecure land rights, are daily obstacles for most Liberian women. These issues are compounded by enduring gender stereotypes and discriminatory cultural practices, which hinder women's ability to reach their full potential.

Although most women are engaged in wage labour or the informal economy, they continue to bear the majority of unpaid care responsibilities. Rural women face particularly steep challenges in economic participation, with their access to markets, financial services and land ownership restricted. The majority work in subsistence farming, with few opportunities to scale up their businesses or access broader economic resources. To lift up Liberian women smallholder farmers from informal and smallholder farming activities, innovative solutions are needed to provide them with access to information, finance and markets.

Approach

UN Women, in partnership with the Orange Foundation in Liberia, is advancing women's financial inclusion and economic activities through the innovative use of technology under the Digital Inclusion for Women's Economic Empowerment (D4WEE) project, which is connecting women to markets, enhancing their access to finance and strengthening disaster risk reduction strategies. Central to this effort is the Buy from Women digital platform, an open-sourced, cloud-based enterprise and e-commerce tool developed by UN Women, which links both women farmers and cooperatives to critical information, financial resources and broader markets.

The initiative also focuses on digitalizing Village Savings and Loans Associations (VSLAs) and integrating them into the formal financial system, thereby enabling access to financial products and services that help scale up businesses. UN Women has collaborated with the Central Bank of Liberia (CBL) to establish secure mobile money platforms for VSLAs, ensuring financial stability and consumer protection. These platforms connect VSLAs to services such as Orange Money and banks, supported by mandatory digital and financial literacy training delivered by the CBL, UN Women and the Orange Foundation. The CBL also monitors platform performance and evaluates the impact of digitalization on VSLA members. The programme also trains women in disaster risk reduction in partnership with the National Disaster Management Agency (NDMA), providing them with the knowledge to build their resilience against potential risks.

Together, these efforts leverage technology to empower women economically and socially, fostering sustainable development in Liberia.

15 women VSLAs
ACCESSED TO FORMAL FINANCE

425 women farmers
BENEFITED

17 cooperatives
INCREASED SALES OF ABOUT US$280,000

1137 new jobs
INCREASED

Results

The initiative has generated significant positive outcomes for 425 rural women farmers in Liberia. By integrating 15 women-led VSLAs into the formal financial system, the project has enabled greater access to financial products and services. Women now benefit from bank accounts and mobile phones linked to Orange Money, addressing their previous exclusion from formal financial channels. This integration offers secure savings, convenient transactions and opportunities for future credit access. Moreover, digitalizing traditional VSLAs has enhanced security and transparency, reducing risks of theft, loss and financial mismanagement through digital record-keeping. This transformation also paves the way for introducing additional financial products, such as micro-insurance or investment options, further expanding financial opportunities for these women.

The project has also driven economic empowerment for these rural women farmers. The Buy from Women platform has tackled market access challenges by connecting women entrepreneurs to a larger customer base, facilitating digital payments through Orange Money. This has resulted in increased sales, with 17 cooperatives generating approximately LRD 52.5 million (about US$280,000). Moreover, the initiative has familiarized women with digital transactions, fostering the broader adoption of mobile money and its associated benefits. Training in digital literacy, financial management and business skills has further enhanced their capacity for long-term success, equipping them to make informed decisions and manage their businesses effectively.

The initiative's impact extends beyond individual beneficiaries to the broader community. The support to women entrepreneurs has created 1,137 new jobs, stimulated local economies and demonstrated the transformative potential of women-led businesses when given adequate resources. The programme's data-driven approach, which collects and analyses information on women's access to finance and digital tools, ensures targeted, evidence-based interventions that maximize effectiveness and sustainability. Finally, by engaging the government, private sector and civil society, the initiative has fostered a supportive ecosystem for women's economic empowerment, which is crucial for scaling up the project and securing its long-term impact.

CONCLUSION

In Liberia, Buy from Women is a transformative programme designed to empower women entrepreneurs in Lofa, Bong and Nimba counties. By enhancing business management skills, fostering strategic networking, and connecting women to critical resources like finance and technology, the initiative addresses key barriers faced by women-owned businesses. Through gender-specific analyses, it ensures tailored solutions to unique challenges are found, while partnerships with companies like Orange amplify their access to innovative tools and to larger markets. Moreover, the programme promotes the economic and social benefits of supporting women-led enterprises, creating opportunities for sustainable growth.

In collaboration with:

CÔTE D'IVOIRE

Country context

Côte d'Ivoire has made notable strides in gender equality and women's empowerment, yet significant challenges remain. Socioeconomic disparities continue to disproportionately impact women and girls, and also exacerbate inequalities in critical areas such as education, health, agriculture, employment and political participation.

Women face major barriers to economic opportunities, with many working in informal, low-wage or agricultural jobs. Despite their vital contributions to agriculture, a key sector of Côte d'Ivoire's economy, women often lack access to land ownership, credit and resources, limiting their ability to produce a cash crop and enter high-productivity employment that would generate a higher income. UN Women's gender equality snapshot highlights these challenges, ranking Côte d'Ivoire low in economic participation and opportunities for women at 122nd out of 146 countries.[22]

As the world's largest producer of cocoa and cashew nuts, Côte d'Ivoire has experienced rapid economic growth in the past decade. However, despite these advance, progress towards gender equality remains gradual.[23] The Ivorian economy relies heavily on informal employment, where women are overrepresented and earn lower wages. Although women generally do not own large farms, they play a crucial role in the agricultural sector, especially in the production and marketing of food crops, comprising 29.9 per cent of the agricultural workforce, 31.6 per cent in industry, 59.5 per cent in trade, and 39.5 per cent in services.[24] Despite women's significant contributions to these sectors, persistent gender discrimination continues to restrict women's full participation and their ability to benefit equitably from the country's economic growth.[25]

Approach

In Côte d'Ivoire, UN Women is rolling out the initiative, Buy from Women, targeting women smallholder farmers and members of women-led agricultural cooperatives in the country's central region, an area where access to markets is relatively poor. The Buy from Women digital e-commerce platform is known as "Blaatto" in Côte d'Ivoire, which means 'come and buy' in the region's Baule language.

Blaatto promotes gender-responsive, cost-efficient and data-driven solutions that empower women entrepreneurs and business owners. The initiative has enhanced women farmers' access to markets, enabling them to sell their products more effectively. The platform Blaatto also strengthens connections between women entrepreneurs, markets and resources and collaboration with Côte d'Ivoire's robust private sector and international financial institutions. The programme has elevated women's expertise through training and resources, ultimately improving the quality of their agricultural products. These comprehensive interventions ensure that women and girls in Côte d'Ivoire are not only empowered but also included in the country's social and economic development.

Results

Harnessing the power of technology and innovation, the Buy from Women e-commerce platform promotes solutions that are gender-responsive, cost-efficient and data-driven and empower women entrepreneurs and business owners. As a vital step towards broader gender equality, this programme ensures that women are empowered, recognized and integrated into Côte d'Ivoire's economic fabric. To ensure sustainability and national ownership, the process of transferring the platform to a national entity is currently underway through a Memorandum of Understanding.

Drawing on South–South cooperation and innovative financing, UN Women mobilizes additional resources to advance gender equality initiatives in partnership with the Ivorian government, the African Development Bank, the European Union, embassies, civil society organizations and human rights institutions. These partnerships boost support for gender equality and promote women's empowerment across all sectors.

CONCLUSION

By fostering connections between women farmers and various market stakeholders, Blaatto has promoted economic independence and empowered women in the agricultural sector, driving progress towards gender equality in Côte d'Ivoire. The platform also supports women in agriculture by improving their skills, expertise and product quality, fostering economic independence and promoting sustainable development within local communities. By supporting rural women in developing income-generating activities, UN Women equips them with essential skills and knowledge, and connects them with markets, information and resources to enhance their economic independence.

In collaboration with:

KOAFEC Korea-Africa Economic Cooperation

IFC International Finance Corporation WORLD BANK GROUP
Creating Markets, Creating Opportunities

we-fi WOMEN ENTREPRENEURS FINANCE INITIATIVE

COSTA RICA

Country context

Costa Rica has made notable progress in advancing gender equality, with significant improvements in areas such as women's political participation, access to education and economic empowerment. These efforts align with broader regional goals of fostering inclusive growth and equal opportunities for all genders. Despite these efforts, challenges remain in achieving full gender parity, especially in the labour market and political leadership roles.[26]

As in other parts of the Latin America and the Caribbean region and globally, men and women in Costa Rica still do not share paid and unpaid work equally, with 47 per cent of women of working age (15 to 64 years old) employed in 2022 compared to 73 per cent of men.[27] Data have also shown that women are less likely to participate in paid employment or work full-time hours. Women and girls spend 23.5 per cent of their time on unpaid care and domestic work, compared to 8.2 per cent spent by men.[28] Informal employment is particularly common among women in rural areas, where more than half work in the informal sector.[29] The banking system is collateral-based, which can make it difficult for women to access credit, especially for SMEs. In 2017, according to the Global Findex, the gender gap in access to credit was 14 per cent, with 75 per cent for men and 61 per cent for women. Meanwhile, 27 per cent of the Costa Rican men saved at a financial institution, compared to 19 per cent of women.

Approach

In the context of the COVID-19 pandemic, in response to the economic turbulence, which severely impacted women entrepreneurs and business owners by restricting their access to markets due to lockdowns and social distancing measures, UN Women, in partnership with various stakeholders through the UN Joint SDG Fund Programme on Social Protection implemented by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO), International Labour Organization (ILO) and UN Women, adapted the Buy from Women (BfW) initiative to create an innovative e-commerce platform. This platform, developed by UN Women, the National Institute for Social Welfare (IMAS) and IMAS's Trust Fund (FIDEIMAS), connects women entrepreneurs and business owners directly to consumers through a business-to-consumer model, providing a critical lifeline to sustain and grow their businesses.

Starting with a comprehensive study involving over 50 women entrepreneurs living in poverty, UN Women identified key barriers to their economic autonomy. The findings revealed that these women required access to broader markets beyond their local communities, along with training and information to improve product quality, formalize their businesses and improve their management capabilities. Moreover, the study highlighted the need to close the digital divide and empower women with technological skills.

To ensure that no one is left behind, a strategic approach was developed to provide targeted training and support for women. UN Women and FIDEIMAS forged partnerships with public institutions, universities and private sector companies to offer the necessary training and continuous support, enabling these women to develop or expand their businesses and succeed on the e-commerce platform.

Results

The programme has yielded significant results. It has empowered women entrepreneurs and business owners by providing them with essential access to markets, information and training. Through the BfW e-commerce platform, called Hecho por Mujeres in Costa Rica, women who face economic vulnerability or live in poverty are now able to reach a broader consumer base beyond their local communities, increasing their sales opportunities.

Moreover, the programme has equipped participants with the knowledge and skills necessary to improve product quality, to formalize their businesses and to strengthen their management capabilities. This has helped bridge the digital divide, empowering women with the technological tools they need to thrive in the digital economy. The combination of market access, training and ongoing support has been instrumental in promo-ting women's economic autonomy, enabling them to overcome barriers and achieve sustainable growth in their businesses. Overall, the programme has not only enhanced women's economic participation but it has also fostered long-term empowerment by providing them with the resources and skills to achieve greater financial independence.

CONCLUSION

UN Women and its partners have played a pivotal role in driving the economic empowerment of women entrepreneurs and business owners in Costa Rica through the Buy from Women e-commerce platform. By partnering with key stakeholders, UN Women has adapted this initiative to address the unique challenges posed by the COVID-19 pandemic, ensuring that women living in poverty or economic vulnerability are not left behind. Through the provision of market access, essential training and ongoing support, UN Women has helped these women improve their businesses, bridge the digital divide and enhance their economic autonomy. This initiative not only strengthens women's financial independence but also promotes gender equality by empowering women to participate fully and equitably in the economy.

In collaboration with:

HAITI

Country context

Haiti continues to be the poorest nation in the Latin America and Caribbean region and ranks among the most impoverished countries globally. Haiti is still among the most at-risk nations globally in terms of natural disasters, particularly hurricanes, floods and earthquakes. Over 96 per cent of its population is vulnerable to these kinds of events. Haiti's economic and social development is hampered by ongoing political instability, rising violence and unprecedented levels of insecurity, all of which contribute to its fragility.[30] In 2023, the female labour force participation was 60.9 per cent compared to the rate of 70.2 per cent for men.[31]

Women and girls are the foundation of Haitian society and its economy. In Haiti, nearly half of households are headed by women, who are essential to the economy as they make up the majority of street vendors and are vital participants in agricultural supply chains. Despite their crucial roles, they continue to face major obstacles, including widespread inequality and gender-based violence.

Approach

UN Women organized a consultation workshop in Port-au-Prince on an e-commerce platform aimed at women entrepreneurs. Feedback was gathered from various stakeholders, including government, the public sector, non-governmental organizations and civil society organizations, covering areas of women's empowerment, agriculture, rural development, trade, and information and communication technology (ICT). Studies were conducted to analyse sectors such as drinking water, energy and key agricultural sectors (e.g. mango, cashew, vetiver, corn, cocoa, castor, honey, coffee and beekeeping) that could potentially be included in the platform.

In collaboration with the French NGO, *Entrepreneurs du Monde*, several steps were taken: an inventory of the existing ICT ecosystem in Haiti was carried out, focusing on digital and mobile platforms, and assessing strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. The process also involved identifying key Haitian IT engineering companies that could contribute to the platform's development, evaluating hosting and operating costs, and gathering data on service costs from mobile phone companies for calls and texts; and criteria were applied to identify the most promising sectors for women's involvement, including the platform's feasibility, sustainability and replicability in the sector, a sector description including key actors, women's participation in the sector and the potential impact of ICT on sectoral activities.

After evaluation and discussion, UN Women chose to focus on the cocoa sector, particularly with producers working alongside the Ayitika organization in the Southern region, as the most promising initiative based on the selected criteria.

Results

The programme successfully mapped opportunities for women entrepreneurs in the sectors of drinking water, renewable energy and agriculture, identifying the unique needs of women in these industries. A key result is the design of a digital platform tailored to women farmers, enabling them to access crucial information, track production and profits, and connect to new markets.

Moreover, valuable sex-disaggregated data have been collected specific to the cocoa sector, including the number of male and female producers, the number of registered cocoa trees, the gender distribution of household heads, and the average age of male and female cocoa producers, offering insights into gender dynamics in this sector.

NOTE

Haiti is grappling with severe political instability, gang violence and a humanitarian crisis. Key challenges such as road blockages, fuel shortages and high food prices further exacerbate the situation. Initial trials of the digital platform revealed several potential constraints for users, including issues related to Internet connectivity, which is either absent or weak, challenges in transporting or delivering exchanged products (marketing circuits), and the payment methods to be adopted. Despite the fact that the platform has come to a halt, UN Women Haiti is still working to determine the best strategy for relaunching it, taking into account the observations made during the trial.

In collaboration with:

NORWEGIAN MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Innovation Norway

AYITIKA TERROIRS DE CACAO

ENTREPRENEURS du Monde

REGIONAL INITIATIVE

CENTRAL AMERICA

BUILDING AN INCLUSIVE FINANCIAL ECOSYSTEM

Women's financial inclusion is a key driver for reducing gender gaps in access to capital and markets, fostering economic empowerment and achieving sustainable development. Providing women with access to financial resources, such as credit, savings and insurance, transforms their lives while contributing to broader economic growth. Bridging the gender gap in financial inclusion is not only a matter of equity but also a smart investment in resilience, innovation and inclusive prosperity. It is a strategic imperative for sustainable development and global social progress.

Regional context

Despite improvements in overall access to financial services, gender gaps remain in Central America. At the regional level, there remains a seven percentage point gap in financial account ownership between men and women, which is higher than the average in emerging markets of six percentage points.[32] In Central America, Honduras and El Salvador have significantly higher gender gaps (20 percentage points in Honduras and 16 in El Salvador), while Guatemala has a 6 percentage point gap.[33]

Financial inclusion is a critical component of women's economic empowerment: access to and the usage of financial products and services supports economic independence and an ability to control one's material environment.[34] One study showed that women reinvest up to 90 per cent of their earnings into their families and communities compared to 30 to 40 per cent by men, amplifying the societal benefits of investing in women's economic participation.[35] Yet financial products are often not designed with women's needs and preferences in mind, overlooking potential gendered constraints such as digital literacy gaps or their lack of the documentation traditionally required by banks. By collecting data that are sex-disaggregated and integrating gender-responsive design processes, financial institutions can better serve new and existing women customers and help to drive women's empowerment in their markets of operation.

Approach

To promote women's financial inclusion and reduce the gender gap in access to capital and markets, UN Women implements the Inclusive Financial Ecosystem Programme in El Salvador, Guatemala and Honduras. The programme works at both national and regional levels, while focusing on capacity-building and the development of diagnostic studies, knowledge products, tools and methodologies, as well as the generation and analysis of sex-disaggregated data. Key efforts include collaborating with financial institutions and service providers to spur innovation in designing financial products and services tailored to women's needs. The programme also engages broader ecosystem actors to develop gender-responsive models for financial services. Funded by the Grand Duchy of Luxembourg, the programme strengthens strategic actors in the financial ecosystems of Central America to advance and monitor women's financial inclusion effectively.

Results

The programme has made significant strides in advancing women's financial inclusion by successfully advocating for its integration into public policies and programmes. Notably, women's financial inclusion has been established as a core pillar in Guatemala's new National Financial Inclusion Strategy (ENIF 2024–2027).

The programme has developed and piloted a self-diagnosis tool for financial institutions, enabling them to identify strengths, weaknesses and opportunities to incorporate gender intelligence into their services. By September 2024, 49 financial institutions across three countries had utilized this tool, with some using the results to draft action plans.

Collaboration and partnerships have been central to the programme's approach. A key partnership was established with Redcamif, a network of microfinance institutions, to enhance data collection and reporting on women's financial health and inclusion. Moreover, the programme has facilitated the creation of alliances among various stakeholders, including banks, micro-finance organizations, financial technology (fintech) companies, cooperatives and public institutions, to incorporate gender perspectives in financial products and services. This effort has culminated in progress towards the design of the Finance for All Network, which will host "co-laboratories", which are national spaces for collaborative innovation in inclusive finance.

Next steps

UN Women's Inclusive Financial Ecosystem programme is working to strengthen the capacities of financial service providers (FSPs) by providing technical assistance for implementing self-diagnosis tools. These tools will enable FSPs to assess their practices and develop action plans that promote women's financial inclusion, driving meaningful change in the financial ecosystem.

The programme is also focused on the development of knowledge products, including tools designed to guide monitoring and evaluation systems. These resources emphasize the collection and use of sex-disaggregated data and the gender analysis of regulatory frameworks, ensuring policies and practices are more inclusive and equitable. Progress continues with the implementation of the Finance for All Network, promoting collaborative action within national co-laboratories to address barriers to financial inclusion. In parallel, strategic partnerships are being advanced to improve gender-focused data collection and analysis, reinforcing the importance of evidence-based approaches to achieving gender-responsive financial systems.

CONCLUSION

UN Women's efforts in Central America, through the Inclusive Financial Ecosystem Programme, have demonstrated the significance of tailored financial services, strategic partnerships and gender-responsive approaches in bridging the financial inclusion gap. As well as promoting equity, this is a strategic investment in inclusive growth and societal progress.

In collaboration with:

Inclusive Financial Ecosystem
CENTRAL AMERICA

REGIONAL INITIATIVE

CENTRAL AMERICA

USING GUARANTEE FUNDS FOR FINANCIAL INCLUSION

Guarantee funds are a transformative tool for advancing gender equality by expanding women entrepreneurs' access to capital. They enhance financial inclusion by: (i) mitigating risk through loan repayment guarantees in justified non-payment cases (excluding intentional delinquency); (ii) reducing collateral-based barriers, enabling women to secure credit; and (iii) relieving financial institutions from reserving resources for assigned risks, as the guarantee fund covers them.

Regional context

Women entrepreneurs face a global credit gap of US$1.5 trillion.[36] In the case of Central America, only 26 per cent of women's MSMEs have access to credit.[37] The barriers that women face in meeting the typical requirements that financial institutions demand are associated with assets that can be collateral and are not normally owned by women (land and property). In many cases, women's credit histories are shorter or less active. This is largely due to structural inequalities that translate into a higher perception of risk for the financial institution, despite the fact that evidence shows that women are actually lower risk customers as they are more trustworthy in repaying their loans.[38] This causes many companies, especially those located at the base of the pyramid whose formalization is limited, to access resources in the informal market.

Annual surveys of financial institutions conducted by the IFC consistently find lower proportions of non-performing loan portfolios for women-owned loans to SMEs compared to the average loan portfolios of SMEs. In Central America, the IFC in a study revealed that after the pandemic one fifth of SMEs at the regional level are owned by women, which amounts to 63,000 companies. Moreover, the leadership of women in SMEs allows women to generate twice as much employment in relation to their male peers. The common challenges found in the countries are many requirements (including guarantees) and a lot of paperwork, which results in high costs in time and adequate access to information. According to the same study, it is estimated that the demand for credit for MSMEs in Central America amounts to US$5,147,700.[39]

This situation justifies the establishment of the Guarantee Fund at the Central American Bank for Economic Integration (CABEI). CABEI currently works with 77 intermediaries in the financial ecosystem and the fund allows credit resources to reach recipients with greater certainty.

Approach

UN Women, through a special agreement, delegated US$1 million during the COVID-19 pandemic to constitute a multi-donor Guarantee Fund at the CABEI, in order to help prevent the closure of women-led businesses and sustain jobs. UN Women's contribution was made through the Women, Local Economy and Territories (MELYT) Programme, funded by the Italian Ministry of Foreign Affairs and International Cooperation (MAECI) through the Italian Agency for Development Cooperation (AICS). This allowed loans to be guaranteed to MSMEs in the countries of northern Central America, thus covering the risk to leverage access to credit for women's businesses mainly for working capital, debt consolidation and investments, among others.

Given the success of the Guarantee Fund and considering other cooperating partners designed similar operations with the CABEI, including the KfW Development Bank and the European Union, a single Guarantee Fund was consolidated in 2023 as a permanent facility, worth US$9.1 million, which focuses on guaranteeing loans to activate the regional business sector by expanding coverage to seven countries, with a cross-cutting approach to gender that stipulates that 50 per cent is allocated to MSMEs managed by women.

This consolidation at the subregional level is an achievement in itself, but more importantly, every US$1 invested becomes more than US$4 in loans for MSMEs. UN Women, in addition to being part of the Fund's Oversight Committee, has promoted the initiative in the territories where it is present and has advised CABEI and its financial intermediaries through its programmes.

Results

The Guarantee Fund, added to CABEI's credit lines, has managed to sustain more than 22,000 women's jobs since its implementation in 2020 and impacted more than 3,200 companies led by women through the placement of more than US$45 million in loans to MSMEs. The term of the loans ranged between 3 and 5 years, and 7 out of 10 loans were between US$400 and US$100,000, which indicates that micro and small enterprises are located in this range and to diversify the risk, 30 per cent of the loans corresponded to medium-sized companies.

22,000
WOMEN'S JOBS SUSTAINED

3,200
WOMEN-LED COMPANIES BENEFITED

$45 MILLION
LOANS TO MSMEs

As of September 2023, the data show significant results of the Guarantee Fund as a permanent facility. The goal of placing collateral was met by leveraging 4.3 times the amount of the loan; in 4 out of 10 loans the intermediary requested a partial complementary guarantee (joint, pledge or mortgage); 74 per cent of the companies that requested the resources were registered companies, 44 per cent of which were medium-sized companies; and the fund managed with its guarantee to add 26 per cent as natural persons to which the smaller loans corresponded.[40]

Moreover, 57 per cent of the loans backed by the guarantees were allocated to working capital and obligations were paid due to the pandemic, such as the issue of suppliers, employees who were unemployed or debts with other intermediaries. The sectors that were financed are those that contribute to regional development such as the agri-food sector, cleaner production, hospitality and tourism, construction, the creative industry, media, commerce and services.

The Guarantee Fund was instrumental in ensuring that women-owned businesses could access the financing needed to increase the resilience of their businesses in the wake of the crisis that went from a health pandemic to a structural crisis in economies. Otherwise, financial institutions would have overlooked this segment.

Financial intermediaries in various forums highlighted the importance of the Guarantee Fund during the pandemic. Moreover, they lauded it as a fundamental axis of development banking since it allows greater inclusion to be achieved by mitigating the risk inherent in the structural problems that exclude women from the formal financial ecosystem. The initial success of the Guarantee Fund led it to be made a permanent facility. Apart from coverage, leverage, conditions and risk mitigation, the decisive factor in the fund's success was to promote financial inclusion with a gender-sensitive approach, which despite the pandemic, strengthened the financial ecosystem to specifically respond to the needs of women business owners.

CONCLUSION

Guarantee funds represent a transformative financial mechanism for advancing gender equality and empowering women entrepreneurs. By mitigating risks and addressing systemic barriers, such as lack of collateral and shorter credit histories, these funds enable women-owned businesses to access formal financial systems with more favourable conditions. The consolidation of CABEI's Guarantee Fund into a permanent facility highlights its critical role in promoting financial inclusion, leveraging investments and sustaining businesses led by women. With more than 22,000 jobs preserved and over 3,200 women-owned enterprises supported, the fund has proven to be a pivotal tool in fostering equitable economic growth and resilience. This experience demonstrates that financial solutions tailored to women's unique circumstances can drive systemic change, strengthening the business sector at both the regional and national levels, while advancing gender-responsive development.

In collaboration with:

AGENZIA ITALIANA PER LA COOPERAZIONE ALLO SVILUPPO

Ministero degli Affari Esteri e della Cooperazione Internazionale

CABEI Central American Bank for Economic Integration

melyt

REGIONAL INITIATIVE

EUROPE AND CENTRAL ASIA

BRINGING A GENDER LENS TO DESIGNING FINANCIAL PRODUCTS AND SERVICES FOR WOMEN

By addressing the specific challenges women face in accessing credit, savings, insurance and investment opportunities, gender-responsive financial services foster women's financial resilience. Tailored financial products, such as flexible loan terms, reduced collateral requirements and greater access to digital financial tools, empower women to manage risks more effectively, invest in their businesses and improve household welfare. This increased financial autonomy enables women to better navigate economic shocks and actively contribute to broader economic growth. This is why banks need training and encouragement to develop gender-responsive financial services and products.

Regional context

In Europe and Central Asia, where women represent a significant source of untapped talent and productivity, advancing gender equality in the labour market could have substantial economic benefits. According to the International Labour Organization (ILO), achieving gender parity in labour force participation could increase the region's GDP by up to US$1.1 trillion, or 23 per cent of its annual output. However, significant barriers remain.[41]

Women's labour force participation is substantially lower than men's—50.6 per cent compared to 66 per cent—and the gender pay gap stands at some 30 per cent.[42] Women are also underrepresented in leadership positions, with obstacles hindering their advancement to senior management roles. Female entrepreneurship is also limited, largely due to restricted access to assets, financial services and vital business information.[43]

Despite recent progress, including reforms in 17 per cent of economies in the region to improve legal gender equality since 2020, gender disparities in financial inclusion persist. The financial inclusion gender gap has stagnated at 6 percentage points since 2017. Women are 15 per cent less likely than men to have savings and 28 per cent less likely to have enough savings to start a business.[44] In the growing digital economy, women are also 8 percentage points less likely than men to make digital payments to merchants.[45]

Financial resilience, which reflects the ability to recover from sudden financial hardship, remains a challenge for women in Europe and Central Asia. The region has one of the highest levels of reliance on informal support networks, such as family and friends, for emergency funds, with 36 per cent of adults citing these sources. These informal channels, however, can be unpredictable, leaving women more vulnerable during financial crises.

Women who lack access to banking and financial services face a higher likelihood of living in poverty, exclusion and vulnerability. Without a secure income, adequate savings or financial services, women are at greater risk of falling deeper into financial instability during emergencies, particularly when reliant on cash or informal borrowing.

Access to formal, gender-responsive financial services is essential for women to build a stable safety net and strengthen their ability to withstand unexpected financial burdens. Gender-responsive financial services can thus play a transformative role in closing these gaps, enhancing women's financial resilience, and driving inclusive economic development across the region.

Approach

UN Women has adopted a comprehensive approach to promoting women's entrepreneurship. Within the framework of a multi-stakeholder initiative, the Women's Entrepreneurship Expo, UN Women collaborates closely with women entrepreneurs to enhance their business skills and support their business growth. Concurrently, it engages financial institutions to encourage the development of banking products tailored to women entrepreneurs.

A "Design Thinking Atelier: How to Develop Financial Products for Women" exemplifying this approach was held in Istanbul on 12 to 13 September 2024, where representatives from three financial institutions based in Albania, Ukraine and Uzbekistan gathered to enhance their understanding on the development of gender-sensitive financial and non-financial products for women and to explore avenues for improving financial inclusion for women entrepreneurs. All companies are signatories of the WEPs in their respective countries and are working closely with UN Women offices.

The sessions, facilitated by leading experts in women's banking, from TEB Bank (Turkey) and the Frankfurt School of Finance and Management, were designed in a way to inspire participants with global best practices, equip banks with the knowledge to define the problems and engage in creative brainstorming to generate a wide range of possible banking products for women.

A part of the programme was to raise awareness of gender issues, and laid the foundation for participating banks to more broadly address gender equality in their approaches and frameworks. The session covered the concept of gender and inequalities, barriers that women face in the economy, unconscious gender biases, the role of the financial sector in gender equality and opportunities for financial institutions.

Photo: UN Women Regional Office for Europe and Central Asia. Participants joined the group discussion at the "Design Thinking Atelier" Workshop in September 2024.

Results

The workshop participants enhanced their knowledge in financial products for women and designed first prototype products for testing and prototypes for innovative financial solutions tailored to women's needs for further testing. The process consisted of several steps:

- **Get inspired:** Participants learned about the global best practices in women's banking.
- **Define:** The participants, inspired by global best practices, then worked in groups to define the problem statement. They then also met with two women entrepreneurs who shared with participants their stories and challenges. The meeting with entrepreneurs was aimed at developing empathy towards their customers.
- **Ideate:** Participants engaged in a creative brainstorm where they generated a wide range of possible solutions for the lack of women's banking products in their respective banks.
- **Prototype:** Once participants had a list of potential solutions, they continued to work in groups to create a tangible representation of the ideas for testing.

The two-day session was concluded with a study visit to TEB's women banking department as well as the co-working space JustWork, where participants met with more entrepreneurs to validate the prototypes they developed.

CONCLUSION

The workshop provided an invaluable opportunity to explore innovative solutions for supporting women entrepreneurs through design thinking. It also provided a space for sharing insights around practical financial inclusivity and tailored services by banks to support women's businesses. For the next steps, UN Women aims to expand this group further and engage more financial institutions. Participants of the workshop will meet on a quarterly basis to monitor progress on the development of the products.

In collaboration with: TEB; Frankfurt School of Finance & Management — German Excellence. Global Relevance.

ICELAND
THE WORLD'S FIRST SOVEREIGN GENDER BOND

The rapid expansion of sustainable finance opens exciting opportunities to channel investments towards advancing gender equality. Lenders, regulators and investors are increasingly integrating gender considerations into their decision-making processes. Integrating gender considerations not only aligns with global development goals but also drives inclusive and impactful growth. Iceland's inaugural sovereign gender bond demonstrates Iceland's leadership in gender equality and its commitment to sustainable finance.

Country context

Iceland has made steady progress towards gender parity since the first Global Gender Gap report in 2006 and has ranked 1st globally for 15 consecutive years.[46] The country has significantly improved its overall gender gap score from 78.1 per cent in 2006 to 93.5 per cent in 2024.[47] Iceland's outstanding progress is primarily due to its strong commitment to gender equality in areas such as education, political representation, economic participation and health.

Although Iceland performs well in global comparisons, full gender equality has yet to be achieved. One of the key obstacles to achieving gender equality is the issue of sexual and gender-based violence.[48] Additional challenges include gender segregation in the labour market and an uneven representation of women in top leadership positions in businesses, which is partially influenced by gender-based education choices. Moreover, the unequal distribution of household and family responsibilities remains a significant challenge.[49]

In 2020, only 35.3 per cent of the SDG indicators needed to assess gender perspectives were available. Gaps persist in tracking unpaid care, domestic work and areas such as gendered poverty, harassment, women's asset access and environmental issues.[50] Gender data deficits hinder effective monitoring and progress evaluation.

The Economic Participation and Opportunity subindex highlights a decline in labour force participation parity, now at 90.3 per cent, compared to its peak of 95.3 per cent in 2015–2016. Wage parity and female representation in senior roles have also decreased since 2021. Despite these setbacks, Iceland has consistently achieved gender parity in technical roles since 2006. According to UN Women's indices, achieving comprehensive and equitable progress requires closing these gaps through better data, targeted interventions and sustained policy support.[51]

Approach

Between 2022 and 2023, Iceland's Ministry of Finance received technical support from UN Women to develop their gender equality financing framework in line with their overall medium-term debt management strategy, aligning with Bonds to Bridge the Gender Gap: A Practitioner's Guide to Using Sustainable Debt for Gender Equality, published by UN Women, the ICMA and the IFC. UN Women provided technical expertise and overall guidance during regular working sessions, leading to the publication of a Gender Equality Annex to Iceland's Sovereign Sustainable Financing Framework, a foundational document which would support their subsequent issuance of the world's first sovereign gender bond in June 2024.

The working group, consisting of UN Women and Ministry of Finance experts, collaborated to draft a dedicated bond framework aligning the proceeds with Iceland's commitments to gender equality. UN Women's role was unique as it pioneered a comprehensive approach to gender bond issuance, aligning with Iceland's ambition for a "gold standard" first issuance. No organization had previously brought together gender-responsive criteria, advanced use of proceeds and rigorous long-term impact indicators grounded in the SDGs and national statistics. UN Women guided the integration of focus areas such as redistributing care, supporting vulnerable women and addressing violence against women. Moreover, UN Women emphasized the role of advocacy groups in monitoring outcomes, ensuring accountability and impact. This innovative approach set a new global benchmark for gender-focused financial instruments.

Results

The government of Iceland issued a EUR 50 million inaugural sovereign gender bond, which aims to channel investments towards projects and enterprises that advance women's economic empowerment and address gender gaps, for instance, projects to end violence against women and girls, address unpaid care work, and provide decent living conditions for women, among other gender equality outcomes. To date, no government had issued thematic bonds fully dedicated to gender equality and this, therefore, represents a global first.

CONCLUSION

Issuing the world's first sovereign gender bond is pivotal because it marks a groundbreaking step in linking national financing to gender equality objectives. Sovereign gender bonds demonstrate how public debt can directly fund initiatives that close gender gaps. This issuance sets a powerful precedent for other nations, signalling that gender equality is integral to sustainable development and economic resilience. Moreover, it attracts investors committed to social impact, fostering a financial ecosystem that values long-term, inclusive growth and strengthens accountability for gender-focused outcomes.

In collaboration with:

SENEGAL

GENDER-RESPONSIVE HEALTH INSURANCE FOR RURAL WOMEN

Health insurance is a vital social protection mechanism, enabling women to mitigate financial risks associated with illness for themselves and their families, while continuing to engage in income-generating activities. It also reduces the strain on women who care for sick family members, allowing them to participate more fully in the economy. Moreover, health insurance contributes to better health outcomes, fostering overall well-being and productivity for individuals and communities.

Country context

In Senegal, rural women make up over two thirds of the agricultural workforce[52] and face significant challenges in accessing healthcare and insurance. These challenges are exacerbated because they bear disproportionate domestic and care responsibilities, which are intensified by the climate crisis. Many women spend substantial time fetching water, cooking and caring for family members, including those with chronic illnesses or disabilities. A study by UN Women showed that rural women in Northern Senegal spent up to 12 hours per day on unpaid care responsibilities. These responsibilities limit their ability to engage in paid work, resulting in increased financial vulnerability and instability.

Illness, whether personal or within the family, is one of the primary barriers to income-generating activities. The financial strain from medical expenses, combined with lost income opportunities, frequently leads to precarious situations, such as household food insecurity, difficulty paying bills and reduced contributions to household finances.

A 2022 survey, conducted in partnership with local Senegalese women's organizations, highlighted the financial difficulties faced by rural women in Senegal. The survey revealed that only 7 per cent of the surveyed women had access to health insurance. In addition, looking at financial services and saving mechanisms, 30 per cent saved money through informal means, and 25 per cent had access to formal credit mechanisms. Most of their daily income is spent on basic needs such as food. Unforeseen costs—for example for medical consultations or family events such as marriage, death and baptisms—can consume over 10 per cent of their monthly income.[53] To cover these expenses, many women rely on informal borrowing from relatives or friends due to limited formal credit options.

LESS THAN
7%
OF WOMEN SURVEYED HAVE HEALTH INSURANCE

85%
OF WOMEN EXPRESSED INTEREST IN HEALTH INSURANCE

Despite the low uptake of health insurance, 85 per cent of surveyed women expressed a strong interest in accessing affordable health insurance, including through digital channels. Inclusive and accessible digital services offer an opportunity to improve access to financial services and social protection. While 90 per cent of the women surveyed owned mobile phones, most used them primarily for calls, missing out on the potential to access financial services and information through these devices.

Approach

In response to these challenges, Senegal's National Health Insurance Agency (CMU) piloted an initiative in late 2022 to extend and adapt its services to meet the needs of rural women, initially in the Saint-Louis region in the North. The pilot targeted the Network of Women Farmers of the North (REFAN) and was supported by ARD Saint-Louis and UN Women. The regular CMU departmental insurance model provides up to 80 per cent coverage for primary healthcare, medicine, medical exams and hospital costs, with an annual premium of CFA 7,000 (about US$11), half of which is subsidized by the government. Special medications are covered at 50 per cent.

CFA 2000-2500

(USD 3.5)

PER SUBSCRIPTION

UP TO 7

FAMILY MEMBERS

UNDER ONE BENEFICIAL SUBSCRIPTION

FLEXIBLE

PAYMENT OPTIONS

INCL. MOBILE MONEY, COMMUNITY-BASED SAVINGS GROUPS

UN Women has provided essential technical support to tailor these services to the needs of rural women. Key aspects of this approach include:

- **Adapting services:** UN Women collaborated with the CMU to modify insurance products by reducing premiums, introducing flexible payment options (including mobile money) and offering incentives for group enrolments through established women's networks. This approach allowed rural women to access health insurance at a lower cost, improving affordability and uptake. The modified insurance also enabled women to register up to seven family members, profiting from these same beneficial premiums. The introduction of these modifications was particularly helpful in addressing rural women's financial constraints and these services were integrated into existing community structures for easier access.
- **Raising awareness and building capacity:** UN Women and the CMU launched awareness campaigns that targeted rural women directly through community outreach programmes and mobile-based training modules. These modules, available in local languages and based on audio messages, ensured that even women with limited literacy skills could benefit from them. The training focused on explaining the benefits of health insurance, how to enrol and the processes involved in making claims. These efforts significantly increased the demand for health insurance services, as many women were previously unaware of how to access or use insurance.
- **Sustainable financing models:** UN Women also supported the establishment of sustainable financing mechanisms to ensure that rural women could maintain their insurance coverage. This included leveraging community-based savings groups, where women pool their resources to collectively pay premiums. Moreover, collective farming fields and in-kind contributions from local municipalities are being considered to subsidize health insurance costs, creating a more sustainable model for financing health insurance premiums. This approach not only facilitated greater enrolment but also ensured that women could continuously benefit from the health coverage without financial strain.

Results

The pilot enabled women farmers to gain facilitated access to an insurance system that reduced the risk of income loss due to illness in their households. These interventions have led to over 1,300 women and household members in rural Senegal enrolling in the national health insurance programme for the first time, providing coverage for nearly 7,000 individuals. This achievement demonstrates impactful gender-responsive financial services in promoting women's empowerment. With a reduced cost of approximately CFA 2,000 to 2,500 (US$ 3.50) per year per subscriber to cover insurance premiums, this initiative is not only effective but also cost-efficient.

Moreover, the initiative has involved active participation from private sector actors, including financial technology companies and service providers, who could help design tailored financial products such as mobile savings mechanisms and layaway options. These innovations are inspiring solutions to further enhance women's access to financial products and health insurance, helping them manage risks and build financial stability. This initiative is currently being replicated in the south of Senegal, targeting an additional 5,000 women by 2025.

CONCLUSION

UN Women's efforts in adapting and scaling up health insurance services in Senegal have provided a safety net for rural women, enabling them to manage health-related risks while improving their financial resilience. By leveraging digital technology, fostering partnerships between the public and private sector, and building women's capacity, UN Women has expanded access to health insurance in rural areas and laid the foundation for future innovations tailored to rural women's needs. This model offers an encouraging solution for empowering women through gender-responsive financial mechanisms, reducing vulnerabilities, and advancing gender equality and women's economic empowerment.

In collaboration with:

CMU COUVERTURE MALADIE UNIVERSELLE

En partenariat avec Canada

URUGUAY

INTEGRATING GENDER EQUALITY IN INNOVATIVE FINANCE FOR CLEAN, GREEN ENERGY

Investments in green energy and women's economic empowerment are deeply interconnected, offering transformative opportunities for sustainable development. Catalytic investment, through instruments like blended finance, which combines development, public and private capital, can help mitigate private investors' concerns over risks, and effectively unlock additional financing and drive investments in initiatives that prioritize sustainable development. A blended finance window coupled with a technical assistance facility can support companies' innovative green technology business models and gender-responsive practices, creating economic opportunities for women, and fostering inclusive growth.

Country context

Uruguay is widely regarded as a decarbonization success story. Currently, 98 per cent of its electricity is generated from renewable sources, a remarkable achievement considering that in 2007, fossil fuels accounted for a third of its energy production.[54] The country has now embarked on the "second stage" of its energy transition, focusing on reducing emissions from the transport sector, which contributes two thirds of Uruguay's total emissions. The government is positioning its energy transition as an opportunity to simultaneously address broader social and development goals.

However, challenges in women's empowerment persist, as the country falls into the lower-middle category on the Women's Empowerment Index,[55] despite the country having entered the high-income tier in Latin America and being known for its generally low poverty rates and high standards of living.[56]

Although sex-disaggregated data are not yet available, Uruguay needs to improve gender and social incluson in decarbonization, through increasing vulnerable groups' access to energy by improving connections, as well as women's participation in the renewable energy sector. Uruguay has incorporated the response to climate change as a core focus of action of the Plan for Gender Equality. A training plan has been developed for incorporating women as, for example, electric bus drivers.[57]

Photo: @REIF_Uruguay. Awareness-raising event on women's participation in decision-making in the energy sector and business, September 2024.

Approach

Uruguay has embraced innovative financial instruments to support its decarbonization goals. For example, in 2022, Uruguay issued a sustainability-linked sovereign bond, and in 2023, it secured a World Bank loan that was the first globally to tie financing conditions directly to environmental performance. Additionally, Uruguay is leveraging blended finance models—using catalytic capital from public or philanthropic sources to attract private sector investment in sustainable development—through initiatives like the Renewable Energy Innovation Fund (REIF).

Launched in 2022 with a US$10 million grant from the United Nations Joint SDG Fund,[58] the REIF is a blended finance vehicle. The grant funds are used to leverage additional financing from seven commercial banks. In its current phase, the fund is expected to mobilize nearly US$80 million in public and private sector investment, propelling Uruguay's second energy transition. The blended finance model is complemented by a technical assistance facility to support firms accessing the fund and to ensure that projects integrate gender equality into their core operations, amplifying social and economic impacts while promoting sustainable development.

UN Women supports Uruguay to make GEWE central to the fund's mission. Projects approved by the REIF are evaluated based on their impact in three key areas: greenhouse gas emission reduction, environmental sustainability, and social impact in which gender is considered for example increased energy access for vulnerable groups and enhanced participation of women in the economy. Firms applying for funds are required to adhere to the WEPs and are expected to significantly improve gender performance indicators with the help of technical assistance.

UN Women offers technical assistance to firms which access REIF financing, helping them integrate gender considerations across their organizations and projects. UN Women also plays a pivotal role in assisting partner commercial banks to integrate gender considerations into credit analysis. Moreover, the programme includes targeted research and UN Women leads efforts to measure and address gender gaps in Uruguay's science, technology, engineering and mathematics (STEM) sectors, supported by the Ministry of Industry and Energy, to inform future policies and private sector strategies.

Results

In September 2023, the REIF approved its first three financial operations, totalling US$1 million in reimbursable financing, which leveraged an additional US$3 million in loans from commercial banks. To date, seven operations totalling US$6.2 million have been approved, including US$1,859,520, which comes from the REIF contribution, while US$4,338,880 is provided through co-financing from banks.

The approved operations focus on two main technology vertical markets. The first is electromobility, which includes vehicles for rent, light-duty utility vehicles and last-mile logistics vehicles. The second is energy efficiency, specifically through lines of credit for heat pumps and storage systems.

From a gender perspective, the sectors targeted by the programme are traditionally male dominated. To support women's access to the economy, UN Women has partnered with the Uruguayan Association of Women in Energy (AUME). This alliance seeks to strengthen the leadership capacities of its members, helping them gain access to decision-making positions. In turn, these women will influence gender policies within their companies. The partnership is currently in the implementation phase, with over 40 members and companies already enrolled to receive training.

7 Projects approved for financing
for a total amount of USD 6.2 million:

REIF
USD 1.86 million

BANK CO-FINANCING
USD 4.33 million

PROJECTS FINANCED TO DATE ARE IN:

Electromobility: Vehicles for rent, light-duty utility vehicles and last mile logistics vehicles

Lines of credit for energy efficiency operations (heat pumps and storage)

CONCLUSION

The energy sector frequently overlooks the inclusion of women as energy users, decision makers and key contributors to a just energy transition. However, by prioritizing a gender perspective, clean energy projects and policies can drive development that benefits entire communities, ensuring no one is left behind. The REIF represents an innovative financing model that catalyses private sector investment in gender-responsive clean energy solutions.

In collaboration with:

JOINT SDG FUND

UNITED NATIONS DEVELOPMENT COORDINATION OFFICE

UNIDO UNITED NATIONS INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT ORGANIZATION

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UNDP

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